

DEBATES IN BLACK POLITICAL THOUGHT - UNIT 3

**WHERE DO WE GO
FROM HERE?**

SMALL GROUPS

- What did the classical phase of the civil rights movement actually accomplish — and what did it leave untouched?
- How does each author explain why formal legal equality was not enough?
- What would a complete movement require practically and formally?

STRATEGIST

Identify moments in each text where the thinker make a concrete claim about the limits of the classical phase and necessary next steps

PHILOSOPHER

Find the language, reasoning, or values the thinkers invoke to justify their answers.

CRITIC

Find moments where your author's argument breaks down, contradicts itself, or requires something it cannot guarantee.

PRESENTER

Listen to, track, and synthesize what your group discovers.

Rustin says the remaining obstacles are structural and economic that persist after legal barriers fall. King says those obstacles are symptoms of something deeper: that racism, poverty, and militarism are a single interconnected system that cannot be addressed one piece at a time. Is this a difference in diagnosis or just a difference in emphasis?

WHOLE GROUP

Rustin dismisses the use moral witness and shock tactics to change white hearts as posture rather than strategy. But King's speech is a sermon that appeals to conscience at every turn. Is King doing what Rustin warns against or is there something King's argument can accomplish that Rustin's framework simply cannot reach?

WHOLE GROUP

Both authors are writing on the assumption that the society they're addressing is capable of responding, either to organized pressure or to moral transformation. Neither of those assumptions turned out to be straightforwardly true. Has the historical outcome of the Civil Rights Movement settled the debate in favor of one author?

WHOLE GROUP

SELF ASSESSMENT

Deep Reading	• I cited specific passages from Rustin and King accurately • I used evidence to support my claims rather than assertion alone • I distinguished between what each author explicitly argues and what he assumes without saying
Quality of Argument	• I stated my position clearly and specifically • I gave reasons, not just conclusions • I responded to the actual questions being asked and debated
Intellectual Honesty	• I acknowledged contradictions and unresolved tensions in both arguments • I genuinely responded to what my peers said • I distinguished between thinking something through and performing that I already knew the answer